

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

BRIMMING BONHOMIE

New Delhi is doing a fine job of walking the diplomatic tightrope on the ongoing Ukraine-Russia war. Even in the face of a sanctions threat from the US, it continues to do business as usual with Russia—indeed, rather more than usual, if you add burgeoning oil imports to the old military trade. For all that, Indo-US relations are going swimmingly well too. PM Narendra Modi and US President Joe Biden will meet at least five times in 2023. First, on the sidelines of the G7 summit at Hiroshima in the third week of May, then at the India-Pacific Island Cooperation Summit in Papua New Guinea on May 22. Two days later, a bilateral is slated after the Quad meet in Sydney. In June, Modi has an official trip to the US. And New Delhi hosts the G20 in September. Will any of this imply a freeze-up with Moscow? Happily, on current form, no.



A Different Health Checkup

Deputy chief minister **Tejashwi Yadav**, who also doubles up as Bihar's health minister, is busy checking the well-being of the state's healthcare facilities. Last September, he started conducting surprise checks on government hospitals—only to be surprised at the state of affairs. Later, he gave his medical mandarins 60 days to improve. On April 30 night, during an inspection at SK Medical College and Hospital, Muzaffarpur, Yadav was faced with the bitter ground realities—from missing doctors to unavailability of medicines. All he could do was promise stern action. But resuscitation may take more than words.

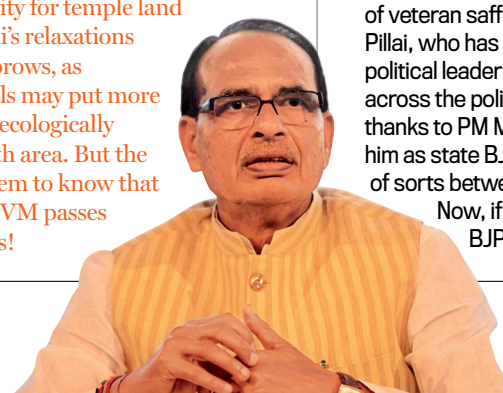


Politics of Emulation?

BJP leaders had drawn parallels between Trinamool Congress national general secretary **Abhishek Banerjee**'s Jana Sanjog Yatra and Congress leader Rahul Gandhi's Bharat Jodo Yatra. But they were at their wits' end on April 29. Because, when Banerjee sat down for lunch at a small-time businessman's humble home in West Bengal's Jalpaiguri district—a la BJP heavyweights Amit Shah and J.P. Nadda—comparisons started being made on that side. The Left was out with its barbs in no time. After all, they keep tom-tomming a secret Modi-Didi entente.

RELIGIOUSLY YOURS

The pressure from the Hindu priest lobby is clearly showing up on the BJP's governments in Uttarakhand and Madhya Pradesh. While Pushkar Singh Dhami's regime was pushed to remove the cap on the number of vehicles and pilgrims in the Char Dham Yatra, **Shivraj Singh Chouhan** is moving closer to conceding the Vishwa Hindu Parishad's long-standing demand of freeing up temples from government control. For now, he has empowered priests as the deciding authority for temple land auctions. Dhami's relaxations have raised eyebrows, as excessive footfalls may put more pressure on the ecologically fragile Joshimath area. But the governments seem to know that the way to the EVM passes through temples!



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

WRITE CONNECT



Writing is not an art of leisure for Goa Governor Dr **P.S. Sreedharan Pillai**. The release of his 198th book on May 2 in Thiruvananthapuram witnessed an unusual gathering. While the book in Malayalam, *Ente Priya Kadakal* (my beloved stories), was released by chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan, the occasion also marked a meeting of veteran saffronites. The 69-year-old Pillai, who has excelled as a leading lawyer, political leader and writer, has friends across the political spectrum. In a way, thanks to PM Modi, whose decision to drop him as state BJP chief has enabled a bridge of sorts between Kerala's political rivals. Now, if only it could shore up the BJP's numbers in the state.

By Pradip R. Sagar, Amitabh Srivastava, Romita Datta, Anilesh S. Mahajan and Jeemon Jacob